Being not only a Kashmiri but also a mainstream leader who joined the rough and tumble of politics over three decades ago, I've never seen such despair and despondency in Jammu and Kashmir before. People are gripped by a crippling sense of insecurity about their identity, land and jobs.

In such distressing circumstances, one can't state enough the crucial role the Congress can play in alleviating the suffering of the people across the state. Let's not forget it was Jawaharlal Nehru's relentless efforts on a personal and political level that ensured Jammu and Kashmir's accession to India. The people of my state placed an enormous amount of trust in his assurances about their future being secure with India. His promises of making Jammu and Kashmir a show window for the world is what convinced a Muslim majority state to throw in their lot with a country where they would be a minority, as opposed to choosing another which was created on the very basis of their own religion. Therefore Jammu and Kashmir's special status wasn't an act of appeasement or privilege, but a matter of right and assurance to a state that made an unusual choice, that, too, at the risk of being subsumed in a country where they would be othered as a minority.

Electorally, Jammu and Kashmir gives six seats to the Lok Sabha. But we are all acutely aware of it being exploited like a milch cow in the run-up to every election. The state in itself is a mini India, where different religions have peacefully coexisted for centuries. For that very reason, the path to save the very Idea of India leads through Jammu and Kashmir. Having said that, the desecration of the Indian Constitution and the subversion of democracy began from Jammu and Kashmir in 2019. It has now dreadfully spread its tentacles through the country.

Today throughout the length and breadth of the erstwhile state of Jammu and Kashmir, the people feel shortchanged. If one turns the pages of history, it's perhaps only the Congress, especially RG, who can understand the pain and dilemma that Jammu and Kashmir has been plunged into. I hope that if the Indian National Developmental Inclusive Alliance (INDIA) does indeed win 2024, it makes efforts to heal the gaping wounds of my people.